BANGALI ADDA: A REASON FOR EXISTENCE OF PUBLIC PLACES IN WEST BENGAL

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Abstract

An *adda,* rendezvous at a particular spot in the locality or *para*, is a form of informal social gathering in Bengali. *Addas* have been a quintessential part of the Bengali culture and for them it is not merely a way to kill time, but a timeless passion. Bengalis would often spend hours at an *adda*; its contents ranging from issues of local politics to more global geopolitical troubles, literature, music, often transcending barriers of age, gender, etc.

This creative performance by the *Bengali Bhodrolok* (read social elite) made *addas* a marker of an ideal middle class identity, especially in response to the cultural hegemony of British Imperialism. Such discussions were often accompanied by hot brew of Darjeeling tea or Coorg coffee. Looking back at the Indian Coffee House situated in the academic hub of Kolkata, it stands as an epitome of such intellectual *addas*. At a later stage, places around Nandan and Rabindra Sadan with a cultural environment also became preferred spots for such discussions, especially among the Bengali youth.

Addas that became popular in 19th century British Bengal had its origin in the narrow platforms outside houses called 'rowaks' and innumerable tea stalls at every street corner. In recent times the flux of multistoried apartments and complexes have replaced these stand-alone middle-class homes in the era of rapid urbanization, drastically reducing the cultural importance that these *adda* zones in the 'rowaks' or tea stalls held in Bengali society.

The shopping mall with open food courts – an architectural combination of covered and open roof spaces with tea and coffee shops have replaced these conventional *adda* spots of Kolkata in the retail environment. Yet it seems its true essence is lost in translation. The external glamour of this modern culture along with the fast life has played a key role in gradual disappearance of the Bengali *adda* losing its way in the jungle of skyscrapers, thereby limiting the profile of Bengali intelligentsia.

Key Words: Addas, Intelligentsia, Culture, Bengal, Social gathering

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From the time of its origin in the village gathering at the Chandimandap, the venue of rustic meetings and festivals, to the literary sessions in the Tagore family at Jorasanko Thakurbari, adda, the informal gossip without any predetermined agenda, has been one of the passions of the Bengalis which is still rooted to the cultural ethos of Kolkata. Its flare touched every element of the city from the suburbs to niches in local 'paras' (localities with big old houses) contributing to the creative performance of the Bengali intelligentsia. Thus adda became an inseparable feature of Bengali culture and became the medium that allowed people to share their creative ideas and thoughts. But with time this original concept of adda is gradually fading away turning its glory into a nostalgic past. The Late legendary singer Manna De's song "Coffee house er sei addata aaj ar nei, aaj aar nei"(The adda at coffee house is no more) aptly narrates the silent decline of the 'adda' culture in Kolkata. The Indian Coffee House, which stands as an epitome of such intellectual addas is almost at the twilight of its vibrancy, weeping for the great minds.



Adda in Coffee House



The Rowaks of North Calcutta

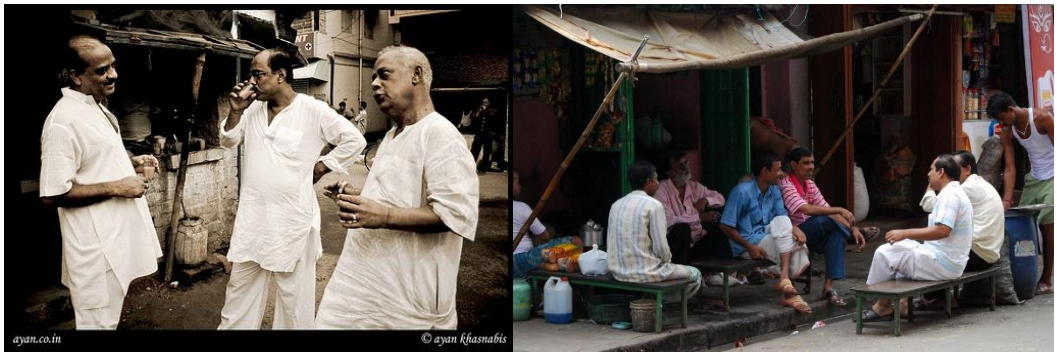
Kolkata: The Evolution of Public Spaces

Supremacy of public spaces has never been debated in Bengali, though public spaces just arose as a matter of fact where more than two people gathered and discussed topics ranging from issues of local politics to more global geo political troubles, literature, music, books, from common daily life, to highly intellectual subjects. Adda just came naturally to the Bengalis as an inevitable event of their daily living, whenever and wherever they could pause, may it be the long queues for bus or meeting the neighbors down the street corners while returning home from work or during the Sunday visits of Bengali 'babus' to the fish market. Adda had become synonymous with the Bengali identity and continues till date. Bengali adda can never be idle, it was and will always be a timeless passion for the people of Bengal. An ideal setting of *adda* is usually a local *chai* shop, pan shop or a street food joint, where people can gather informally and have passionate discussions over a hot cup of tea, in coffee shops, Flurry's, Coffee House of Kolkata, near Victoria Memorial and Nandan Complex or on the steps of Dakshinapan Shopping complex .Though the spirit, interpretation and practices have changed keeping in tune the expanding experiences and influences and spaces associated with them. Bengal with its immensely diverse aggregation of cultures has easily moulded itself to such changes over the years and has warmly embraced all such transformations within its fabric. Public spaces acted as a womb where literature and art were born and nurtured amidst countless cups of tea in 'bhars' (clay pots). This creative activity by the Bengali elites made addas a marker of an ideal middle class identity, especially in response to the cultural hegemony of British Imperialism.

BENGALI ADDA CHARACTERISING PUBLIC SPACES

Adda is said to have originated during the erstwhile zamindari system prevalent in Bengal when the zamindar or the landlords were surrounded by his moshahebs or sycophants who often used to indulge in addas over wine and music. The famous Bengali adda also had its roots in the villages, where elders used to assemble together and discuss local politics. Over a period of time, things changed and the literary sessions came into being, which were made fashionable by the illustrious Tagore family of Jorasanko.

The 'Monday Club' came into being with luminaries like Sukumar Roy, Dr. B C Roy and P Mahalanobis. The birth of the Bengal Renaissance is said to have originated from the adda which was held in the house of the famous teacher and poet Henry Louise Vivian Derozio in the early 19th century. Moreover, the addas held in the office premises of the reputed periodicals like Probashi, Porichay, Shanibarer Chithi, Kallol and Desh were known for their contribution in the evolution of the Bengali culture and tradition. There was a time when modern brands like Baristas and Café Coffee Day had not yet come into being, instead the place which till date stands as the epitome of such intellectual ideas was the Coffee House, situated in the academic hub of Kolkata. Here vivid personalities met, took part in everlasting intellectual addas, exchanged ideas which ultimately led to matchless creations in different fields of art and culture. Consequently, such addas had an enormous impact on the peerless creativity of the renowned Bengalis of the times.



Adda at local tea stalls

Public spaces in Pre-Colonial Kolkata

Pre-Colonial Kolkata was a cluster of prosperous villages. Public spaces in these villages existed in the form of ghats, village markets, temples, chandimandaps and playgrounds which strictly enforced caste and gender segregation, a prime example being the fact that women were strictly prohibited from sharing their thoughts and taking part in the various forms of addas. Movable artisans like bioscope-men, monkey handlers, and street performers etc. provided the limited entertainment for the village people and attracted a sizeable public, thereby turning every open area into a public space.

Colonial Kolkata: regularizing the public spaces. Colonial rule separated the white and the native parts of the town and controlling the lifestyle of the subjects so that they could rule without trouble. First planned public space in Colonial Kolkata was the Maidan which still serves as the most inclusive public space in Kolkata. It was not created with the intent of serving as a public place but was necessitated by the need to have a clear line of fire in case the Fort is attacked. Scale of public spaces varied with white town displaying monumental open spaces and buildings like the Town hall (built in 1814) to be used for public meetings. Public spaces in British part of the city were used for recreation like evening strolls, shopping and eating out but Native Kolkata's public spaces served the cause of daily activities. Traditional public spaces like rocks (an elevated plinth extending outside houses), tea-shops, one room para (neighborhood) clubhouses, byayam samity (association for exercise), Mahila Sammilani (ladies association), local playgrounds and other everyday spaces continued to be popular among the citizens.

BENGALI ADDA CHARACTERISING PUBLIC SPACES

Public spaces: post-independence Kolkata. Though the cultural and social milieu of the city has gone through incredible transformation in the past decades and has been exposed to varied ethos of colonialism, nationalism etc. Kolkata has managed to hold on to some unique determinants of its public realm .Everyday public places based on activities, literally and cultural inheritance still dominate the public sphere and are revered more than the malls and other temples of modernism. Contemporary public spaces in Kolkata can be categorized into following types:
(i) Traditional public spaces reliant on para culture like the club house, vacant lots, grocery shops, rocks in front of houses etc. No concept of contest exists here and participation is total.
(ii) Everyday spaces accessed daily like the public thoroughfares, street temples around trees, bus stops, which function as public spaces solely based on participation not spatial attributes.
(iii) Public places specifically serving cultural and literally meet-ups like the Nandan complex, Fine Arts Academy, Madhusudan Mancha, Dakshinapan where frequent literary and cultural shows are organized which attract the layperson as well as cultural connoisseurs.
(iv) Quasi - public spaces like malls, shopping centre, paid entertainment zones and parks etc. which render public services but is under private ownership or control.

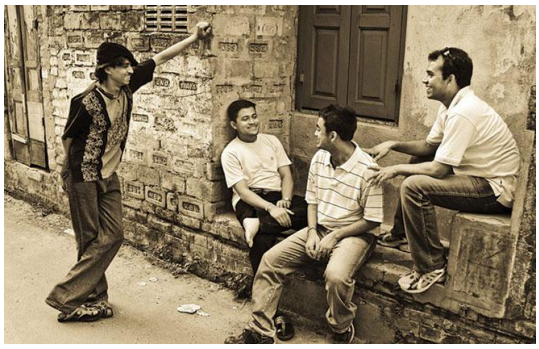


Pavement Setting for adda



Adda at Nandan

Public spaces in Present times. Adda has seeped inside the ‘paras’ (localities with big old houses) of the city and its suburbs, where every evening or Sunday mornings people could be seen gathering at the small tea-stalls in the street corners discussing topics ranging from local politics, breaking news, books to common daily rigmarole over a cup of tea. A small cemented block right beside the entrance, attached with the house (called rowaks or rocks), once a common feature in Kolkata was a perfect place for adda in the open .Morning through evening and at times till midnight, these rocks used to be blocked by various groups or section of people for their addas covering a broad spectrum of topics. Adda also continued on the benches in parks or public playgrounds and local clubs and restaurants. These local gatherings or addas were the stepping stones which gradually gave rise to the modern public spaces.



Adda continued on the rowaks



Adda in a local restaurant

BENGALI ADDA CHARACTERISING PUBLIC SPACES

The informal chit-chats with friends and like-minded people in a hangout or even at a corner of a street – is gradually eroding from the landscape of this cultural city with most of the localities being replaced with multi-storied housing complexes. As a result the Bengali 'adda' culture is on the wane. With the rapid urbanization, Bengal is gradually losing its old houses resulting into quick vanish of these 'rocks' as well. Besides that, with the change in generations the work schedule of people has changed due to the prevailing corporate culture. No more are there those fixed times in work life, when one was sure to be back home by six-in-the-evening and still would have time to freshen up and rush for an evening adda. The lifestyle of the teenage & the youth has changed as well. Further, technological advancement has made people leading a hectic lifestyle more inclined towards devoting their time on the internet, rather than indulging in an adda with their friends. Coffee House at College Street, that stood testimony to the long addas of intellectuals as well as common people from diverse creative fields where one used to share his/her creative ideas at one point of time, is now a witness to the slump of the adda culture which is gradually losing its way into a nostalgic past.



Adda in the Food Court



Adda in an open environment at Tea Junction within a Mall

Now, that very Bengali adda is losing its sheen and with time is fading away with its glorious past. People are frequenting the various luxurious malls of the city, the din of the crowd rarely offering the ambiance for an adda. The mushrooming branded coffee shops have the facilities, but lack the personal warmth that adda-goers felt in their corner tea stall. The missing of the human touch to a more mechanical way of life is another big reason for the change in the trend of 'hanging out' with friends. Frequenting the shopping and entertainment hubs in large numbers, many young adults have discovered their own exclusive zones where they can hang out with friends. The niche hangout zones are quite varied and unique - from the stairs at Forum Courtyard to the top floor parking lot at South City Mall to the quiet benches behind City Centre, the terrace next to the food court at Mani Square or seating spaces just outside the Acropolis Mall or Food court in Metropolis Mall. Although such places guided by consumerism provide entertainment and recreation to people, they however lack the warmth, zeal and passion of the evergreen Bengali adda. Today malls like City Centre 1 and 2 have been deliberately designed with landscaped open or semi open spaces with arrangements for seating and lined with food, tea or coffee stalls to encourage and revive the Bengali adda although with an overtone of consumerism. Not only have the malls adapted to this change but also other public joints like Tea Junction, has beautiful outdoor seating in all its outlets thereby giving a nostaligic feeling of the addas that once happened at the local tea stalls. With gradual urbanisation branded coffee shops, open food courts and swanky malls have gradually increased in the city fabric and have become a part of our hectic modern lifestyle. Modern technologies have made chatting with friends and family so easily possible through a mechanical device, the true essence of Bengali adda over a cup of tea has somehow lost its way.



Semi- open space within a modern mall



Space outside a mall developing into an adda zone

However, despite the availability of all such recreations, entertainment and modern grandeur, a Bengali, in the very core of his/her heart still pines for those Bharer cha, soothing their throats in the winter mornings, heated discussions over a game of carom, late night gossip on the threshold rocks, childhood stories of elders, and mostly experiencing the true warmth in the proximity of their near and dear ones. Bengali adda – which ranges from politics, food, sports, music to childhood stories and experiences of elders, is missed by one and all, and every Bengali soul yearns for the rebirth of such addas in the near future. Hence open type spaces can be integrated within the design of modern public buildings to revive the nostalgic adda once again and encourage the people bogged down with mundane hectic life to exchange their creative ideas and thoughts thus enriching the Bengali culture in various ways once again.

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